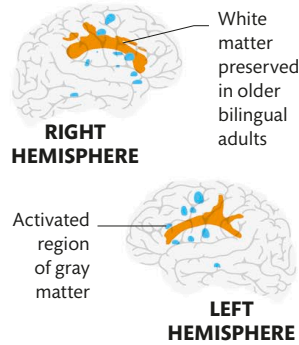




The bilingual brain

In the brain of a bilingual speaker, languages “compete” for attention. This provides unconscious practice in ignoring irrelevant information, and studies show that bilinguals are better at this than monolinguals. The ability to learn a second language like a native speaker is usually lost after around four years of age, especially with pronunciation. The brains of elderly bilinguals show better preservation of white matter, which may protect them from the effects of cognitive decline.



Bilingualism areas
Areas of gray matter (shown in blue) are activated in bilingual speakers when they switch between languages.

ALCOHOL AND LANGUAGE

One study of second-language learners looked at whether alcoholic drinks would improve speaking and pronunciation by reducing self-consciousness. It worked up to a point—but after too many drinks, performance rapidly deteriorated.

